

8.2.1 Page File Size

XP uses the page file dynamically, that is, the page file grows or shrinks according to need. The page file is often given a minimum value and a maximum value, where the minimum value defines the guaranteed space allocated to the page file and the maximum value defines the limit to which the page file can grow. With a maximum and minimum value set, XP has to resize the page file on the fly. Setting the maximum and minimum value to the same number results in more efficient handling of the page file, since XP won't have to waste time resizing the page file.

Setting the size of the page file

Go to the 'System Properties' page. Here, go to the 'Advanced' tab and then select 'Settings'. In the window that opens, go to the 'Advanced' tab; towards the bottom of the tab, you will find 'Virtual memory settings'. Click 'Change'.

In the next window that opens, you can select the drive on which you want the page file to reside; by default, the page file resides on the C: drive. You can also see the page file size. To change it, click on 'Custom Size' and then key in the initial and maximum sizes to be the same. Typically, 1 GB of page file is more than enough for most users, so key in "1024" as your initial and maximum page file size.

8.2.2 Page File Location

Setting the location of the page file

Keeping the page file on the same drive as the operating system is not advised, as the page file requires intermittent read and write cycles that can significantly affect the performance of the system. But most machines have one drive, and there is hardly an option other than placing it along with the OS.

Some people advocate partitioning your drive and placing the page file in a non-OS partition; we doubt if this will help. But if you have a second drive, we advise you place the page file on the non-OS drive for better performance.